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STAFF MEMO

Date: September 2, 2025

To: Board of Education

From: Dr. Jon Franco, Senior Chief of Operations

Subject: 2025 Bond Seismic Program Update for September 9, 2025, Board Meeting

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The structural engineer engaged to provide a seismic assessment and prioritization and risk scoring of PPS school buildings has completed their report and delivered it to the Office of School Modernization (OSM). In the report, the engineers describe two approaches to investing in seismic improvements across the district. One approach is by completing full campus seismic retrofits at the 8-10 highest risk campuses. The other approach is to correct the highest risk deficiencies across the whole district. OSM recommends a hybrid of these two approaches. Whole building improvements are eligible for Seismic Rehabilitation Grant Program (SRGP) grants from the state. Addressing the highest risk building parts across the district maximizes the seismic risk reduction across the District. A hybrid approach will maximize grant potential and maximum risk reduction.

BACKGROUND

In May, 2025, voters approved a general obligation bond to complete capital improvement projects for Portland Public Schools. On May 6, 2025, the Board passed Resolution 7109 - Urgent Need for Seismic Retrofitting of High-Risk School Buildings.

The 2025 Bond planning documents identified $190 million of funding for Deferred Maintenance & Priority Scope. Resolution 7109 directed Staff to establish “a reserve fund necessary for emergency, system end-of-useful life replacement and unplanned projects to respond to imminent or risks to students or PPS personnel, assumed to be in the range of $100 million over the life of the bond.” The resolution also requires that, “Beyond the funds needed for that reserve, there shall be a default presumption that the first and highest use of funds available to address critical repairs and improvements at middle and elementary schools is to mitigate the seismic deficiencies at the 8-10 schools assessed to pose the greatest risk of injury or death in a significant seismic event.”

CURRENT PHASE – PRIORITIZATION AND PLANNING

PPS is in the process of updating existing seismic conditions and project prioritization. This process is being accomplished in 3 steps:

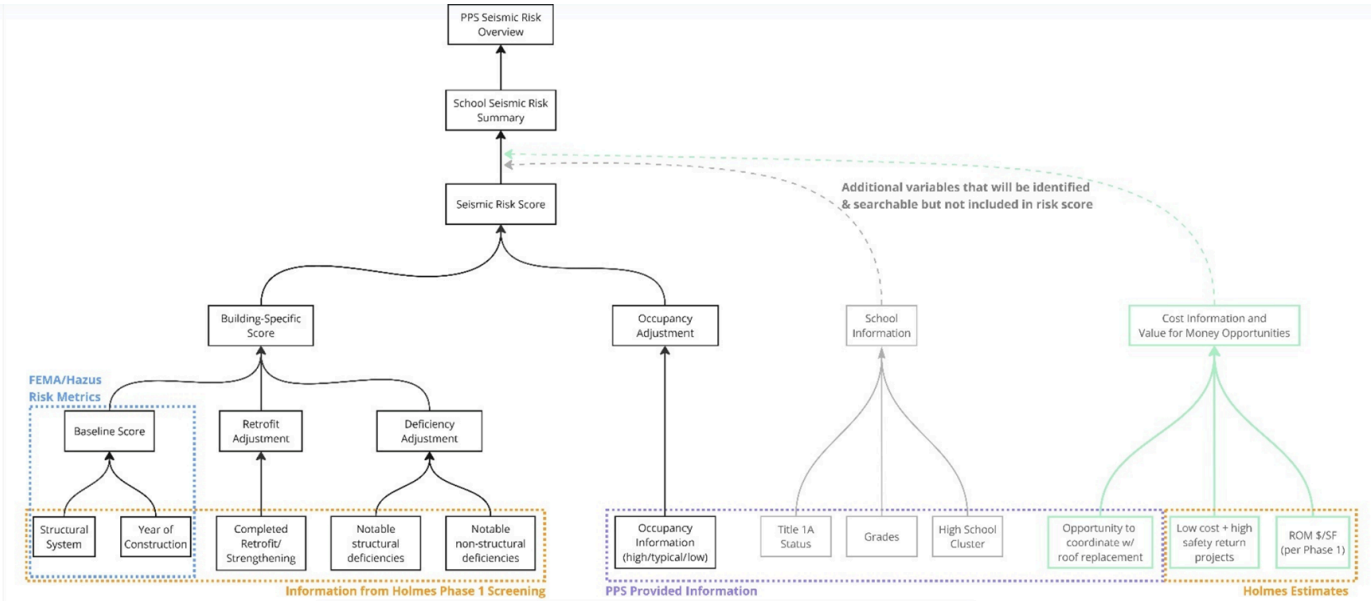
1. Gather detailed seismic deficiency data at all schools - Complete
2. Obtain priority recommendations from structural engineer - Complete
3. Evaluate recommendations Using PPS priority criteria - To Be Completed

1. Seismic Deficiency Data - Complete

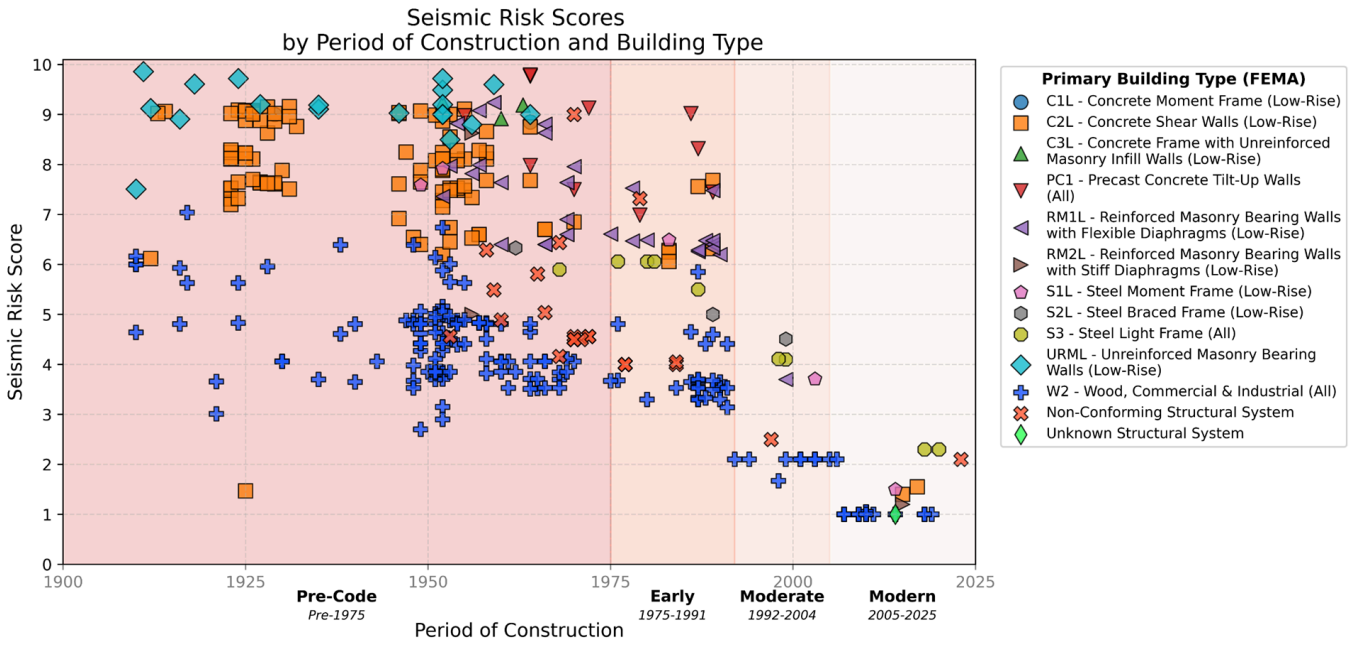
In mid-2024, a structural engineering consultant delivered a high level seismic assessment report for all school buildings. The high level assessment report includes seismic vulnerabilities and rough order of magnitude (ROM) construction costs to correct the vulnerabilities.

2. Priority and Risk Scoring Recommendations - Complete

At the end of 2024, a new contract was established with the engineering firm to develop a prioritization and risk scoring of the identified seismic work documented in the 2024 assessment. The prioritization work included collaborating with the District to define the criteria by which the work is prioritized, completing the prioritization, and developing a report. The report is complete. The methodology for scoring the risks for each school building part is described in the report. A visualization of the methodology is below.



The scatter plot below shows the risk score for every school building part assessed in the scope of the report. A “building part” is a part of a school property that has a distinct structural system. Most school properties have multiple building parts, and those building parts may have different risk scores. The different symbols represent different types of structural systems. The X-axis is the year of construction of the building part.



The structural engineer recommends that PPS use the Risk Scores provided in this report as a primary decision-making tool for allocating seismic upgrade funds and that the scores and identified seismic deficiencies be integrated into future discussions regarding district enrollment changes and facility planning. The engineers propose two approaches to investing in seismic improvements across the district.

Approach A: Campus-by-Campus Implementation

Under this approach, PPS would prioritize the highest-risk campuses and address all seismic deficiencies comprehensively at each selected site. This method treats each campus as a complete project, similar to the district's high school modernization initiatives, where all buildings and building parts receive full seismic retrofitting or replacement regardless of the risk scores of individual building parts.

Advantages: This approach maximizes construction efficiency by concentrating resources at fewer locations, reducing mobilization costs and project management complexity. It ensures complete seismic compliance for prioritized campuses. Complete projects are also candidates for the State's Seismic Rehabilitation Grant Program (SRGP).

Disadvantages: Funding will be spent on some lower-risk building components within high-risk campuses, and overall district-wide risk reduction will be limited to fewer sites.

Approach B: Highest-Risk Building Parts

This approach targets individual *building parts* with the highest risk scores across the district, regardless of campus location. Implementation would focus on the most critical seismic risk building parts first, while also considering cost-effective retrofit opportunities (identified within this report) that provide maximum safety improvement per dollar spent.

Advantages: This method achieves the greatest district-wide risk reduction and protects the largest number of students by addressing the most dangerous conditions first. It provides more immediate safety improvements across multiple schools.

Disadvantages: Higher construction mobilization costs due to projects being distributed across numerous campuses, and increased project management complexity.

OSM recommends a hybrid of Approaches A and B that maximizes both grant opportunities by prioritizing some complete campus retrofit AND maximizes the reduction of seismic risk of the district by addressing individual high-risk building parts.

3. PPS Priority Criteria - To Be Completed

The final and critical step for PPS will be to review the engineers' recommendations and apply its own priorities and criteria to determine which projects should move forward. While the recommendations from phases one and two will provide a strong data-driven foundation, PPS will need to consider additional factors outside the engineers' scope. These include anticipated impacts of potential school consolidation, the feasibility and consequences of multi-summer construction schedules, and potential disruptions to ongoing programs such as summer school. This internal evaluation will ensure that Project decisions align with both operational realities and district-wide educational goals.

NEXT PHASE – EXECUTION PHASE

In the execution phase, OSM will execute the prioritized seismic improvement projects according to its Standard Operating Procedures for bond-funded construction programs. OSM will establish key performance indicators (KPIs) related to the Seismic program. Accountability and transparency will be provided through the following:

- OSM will report the status of the Seismic Upgrade Program bimonthly to the Facility Improvement and Oversight (FIO) Committee in a dashboard style report that communicates the status of the scope, schedule, and budget for each identified project.
- OSM will also report the status of the program to the Bond Accountability Committee.
- A 2025 Bond Seismic Improvements website will provide updates to the public.
- The Seismic Improvements Program will be included in the annual performance audits that will cover the 2025 Bond as a whole.